

HILDEGARD OF BINGEN

A leading authority on medieval pharmacology, Hildegard was a naturalist and healer who explored the medicinal use of plants and animals.

Hildegard was born in Bermersheim, Germany, the youngest child in a family of minor nobility, in 1098. After suffering ill health and seeing visions as a child, she entered a Benedictine abbey at the age of 8. She was made abbess in 1136 and began to study medical treatises from antiquity. She wrote on geology, science, botany, and healthcare, and her work on blood circulation and mental health was advanced for the time. Hildegard prescribed herbs and botanical tonics as both prevention and cure for specific diseases. She believed that ill health was caused by an imbalance in the four humors—blood, yellow bile, black bile, and phlegm.

MILESTONES

NATURAL REMEDIES

In c.1150, writes *Physica*, a nine-volume text listing remedies made from plant and animal extracts.

CURING SICKNESS

Produces major work, *Causae et Curae*, on diseases and their treatments, in c.1150.

MADE SAINT

Beatified by Pope John XXII in 1326; becomes St. Hildegard of Bingen in 2012.

“Gaze at the **beauty** of the **green Earth**. Now, **think.**”

Hildegard of Bingen

Hildegard composed her Book of Divine Works between 1163 and 1174. It was seen as her most complex work and revealed her visionary approach.

